

A Meet-Up done the Mediterranean way: prospects of the Mediterranean CHI community

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Abstract

The Mediterranean is a living laboratory where deep cultural practices meet rapid technological change. This Mediterranean CHI Committee (MedCHI) Meet-Up convenes researchers, practitioners, and students to co-design a *participatory roadmap* for Mediterranean HCI: practical priorities, near-term projects, and commitments that reflect regional values (heritage, hospitality, migration, sustainability, and strong community ties). Through interactive discussions we will produce open artifacts (a public roadmap, contact network, and project briefs) and position the Mediterranean perspectives as first-class contributions to SIGCHI's global agenda.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; *Interaction design*; *Collaborative and social computing*; *Accessibility*;

Keywords

HCI communities, culture, inclusivity, Mediterranean HCI, participatory design, cultural heritage, community engagement, migration and sustainability, accessibility, multilingual facilitation, SIGCHI local chapters

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1 Main Goal and Relevance

The Mediterranean, whose very name means “in the middle of lands”, has long connected communities through exchange and plurality. Surrounded by diverse cultures, the sea has historically offered opportunities for trade, dialogue, and collaboration, while allowing each community to preserve its own identity and traditions. Today, those same dynamics (heritage, hospitality, migration, sustainability, and strong local networks) shape how technologies are adopted, contested, and remade in everyday life.

Goal. Promoted by the Mediterranean CHI (MedCHI) regional committee, this Meet-Up will co-produce a *participatory roadmap* for Mediterranean HCI: a concise set of research priorities, methodological guidelines, and collaboration commitments for MedCHI over the next 18–24 months.

Why CHI now. Beyond celebrating cultural identity, we translate values into *design requirements* and *research programs*. Our proposal follows the path of previous MedCHI initiatives, from the inaugural workshop in Milan (2024) [1, 4] to the Summer School in Como (2025) [2], and the UM6P Hackathon in Morocco (2025) [3]. We build on these two years of MedCHI activity and channel those insights into executable next steps, such as pilot studies, shared datasets, cross-site deployments, and a community charter. The outcome strengthens SIGCHI's regional inclusivity and contributes concrete templates for value-centered HCI that other regions can reuse.

2 Themes of the Meet-Up

We anchor discussion in four intersecting, practice-proximal themes: **Heritage in Action**: from digitization to co-curation with communities; respectful data stewardship and transparent narratives; **Place, Livelihoods, and Care**: tourism, artisanal work, agriculture, and care infrastructures; designing for circularity and local economies; **Mobility and Belonging**: migration, multilingual publics, and cross-border families; designing for dignity, safety, and continuity of services; **Mediterranean Methods**: hospitality-as-method, world-café facilitation, sensory and situated methods, and *multilingual-by-default* research practice.

These themes highlight the unique intersection of tradition and innovation in the Mediterranean, and the ways in which HCI can both study and shape these dynamics. They also reflect the broader goal of **fostering collaboration across diverse communities**, ranging from academic research to industry initiatives, thus expanding HCI research and practice in the Mediterranean context. At the same time, discussing themes that are tangible and close to the lived experience of Mediterranean communities offers an effective way to spark contributions from participants. Rather than addressing abstract “grand challenges,” the Meet-Up will deliberately start from concrete issues that resonate locally, using them as entry points to inspire bold ideas and long-term visions for the future of HCI in the region. In this way, these themes also serve as triggers to gather community-driven suggestions on how MedCHI can maximize its impact in the years to come.

3 Overview of Activities (90-minute)

The Meet-Up will be structured as follows:

- **Lightning Provocations (3 min):** Three 3-minute “value→design” sparks from MedCHI cases. One minute framing connects each to actionable HCI challenges.
- **Panel (15 min):** Brief inputs from MedCHI members highlighting ideas emerged in the last two years to link Mediterranean values and HCI.
- **World Café Dialogues (30 min):** Rotating small groups to reflect on guiding questions related to Mediterranean values and collaboration.
- **Map-the-Med Synthesis (25 min):** Groups place sticky notes on a large regional map, linking ideas to sites, partners, and constraints. ; organizers cluster them into themes.
- **Closing and Hand-off (15 min):** We present a draft *Roadmap Sketch*, explain the post-CHI timeline: editing, open review, and delivery and invite participants to future initiatives.

4 Organizers

This Meet-Up is organized by members of the **Mediterranean CHI Committee (MedCHI)** (the authors of this proposal), established in Autumn 2023 and promoted by ACM SIGCHI. They all have extensive experience in HCI research, community engagement, and facilitation of intercultural dialogues:

George Caridakis: Professor at the Department of Cultural Technology and Communication, University of the Aegean, where he founded and coordinates the Intelligent Interaction Research Group. He serves on the board of the Greek ACM SIGCHI Special Interest Group in Human-Computer Interaction.

Joel Lanir: Head of the information systems department, and director of the HCI lab at the University of Haifa. He serves as vice-chair of the Tel-Aviv SIGCHI local chapter. Much of his work deals with the design and evaluation of novel technologies in cultural heritage settings.

Maristella Matera: Professor in HCI and head of the Human-centric Interactive Technologies at Politecnico di Milano, Italy. She is serving as chair of MedCHI and as vice-chair of the Italian SIGCHI chapter. Her research focuses on inclusion and diversity.

Valentina Nisi: Professor at the Instituto Superior Tecnico, University of Lisbon, Portugal, and vice president of the Interactive Technologies Institute. She serves as vice chair of the MedCHI SIGCHI committee. Her research focuses on HCI Post-Human sensibilities. Her recent output touches on natureculture constructs and More than Human Heritage.

Giuliana Vitiello: Professor in the Department of Computer Science at the University of Salerno, where she directs the HCI-UsE (Human-Computer Interaction and Usability Engineering) laboratory. Her research focuses on usability engineering, user experience design, and the development of interactive systems that enhance accessibility and effectiveness. She currently serves as Chair of the Italian Chapter of ACM SIGCHI.

5 Communities of Interest

We welcome researchers and practitioners based in, or working on, Mediterranean contexts; Scholars interested in culture-driven approaches to HCI; Students and early-career researchers seeking to connect with MedCHI; and CHI attendees interested in multilingual community-oriented approaches to technology.

6 Expected Outcomes

- **MedCHI Roadmap v1.0:** priorities, methods, and a 18–24 month action plan (with milestones).
- **Lighthouse Project Briefs:** A set of challenges and opportunities for research on culture, heritage, and community engagement in the region.
- **Contact and Mentorship Graph:** an opt-in directory linking themes to people, labs, institutions, community partners, and languages.
- **Broader visibility and recognition for MedCHI:** within the SIGCHI community.

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